

# A Decoupled Dual-Microcontroller Architecture for Low-Latency 2D LiDAR SLAM and Autonomous Frontier Exploration

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**ABSTRACT**—Autonomous mobile ground robots operating in GPS-denied environments require deterministic closed-loop motor regulation, high-throughput laser range-finding telemetry, and microsecond temporal synchronization. Conventional single-microcontroller platforms consolidate high-frequency quadrature encoder interrupts ( $> 1 \text{ kHz}$ ), velocity PID feedback, laser serial telemetry (**115,200 baud**), and wireless transport onto a shared MCU, inducing severe interrupt starvation (**14.82%** dropped encoder edges), cumulative dead-reckoning rotational drift ( **$8.45^\circ/10 \text{ m}$** ), dynamic heap fragmentation ( $< 40 \text{ kB}$  free RAM, crashing within **18.4 min**), and motor back-EMF inductive voltage sags (**1.42 V**) that trigger brownout resets. This paper introduces **SLAM BOT**, an edge-decoupled dual-microcontroller architecture and distributed ROS 2 Humble mapping ecosystem. Physical actuation is isolated on an Arduino Uno R4 WiFi (48 MHz ARM Cortex-M4) powered directly from a 7.4V battery pack to its VIN pin for 100% brownout immunity, executing deterministic 50 Hz PID velocity loops. Optical LiDAR acquisition is governed by a NodeMCU ESP8266 (160 MHz Tensilica L106) utilizing a zero-allocation static ring buffer binary serialization pipeline and an adaptive running-minimum clock filter. Over 50 experimental trials, SLAM Bot achieves a **78.11%** reduction in rotational odometric drift ( **$8.45^\circ \rightarrow 1.85^\circ$** ), **100.0%** encoder tick retention (**0.00%** dropped vs **14.82%**), an **86.55%** reduction in telemetry latency ( **$28.4 \text{ ms} \rightarrow 3.82 \text{ ms}$** ), **0.00%** heap fragmentation over 12 hours (**38.4 kB** flat), **100.0%** brownout elimination, and **42.34%** faster autonomous exploration (**222 s** vs **385 s**).

**INDEX TERMS**—SLAM Bot, Edge-Decoupled Architecture, Dual-Microcontroller Robotics, 2D LiDAR Graph SLAM, Ceres Solver, Frontier Exploration, Brownout Immunity.

## I. INTRODUCTION

**A**UTONOMOUS ground vehicles (AGVs) operating in indoor environments depend critically on the integration of low-level mechatronic actuation and high-level spatial perception. **SLAM Bot** is an open, edge-decoupled differential-drive mobile robotics platform engineered to overcome the fundamental hardware and timing bottlenecks that afflict resource-constrained robotic systems.

**What is SLAM Bot?** Physically, SLAM Bot is a differential-drive ground robot equipped with optical laser range finding (RPLIDAR A1M8), dual N20 DC geared motors with quadrature wheel encoders (**360 pulses/rev**), and dual-H-bridge motor drivers. Architecture-wise, it employs a heterogeneous multi-microcontroller hierarchy: an Arduino Uno R4 WiFi (48 MHz ARM Cortex-M4) dedicated exclusively to real-time kinematic regulation and interrupt-driven encoder capture, coupled with a NodeMCU ESP8266 (160 MHz Tensilica L106) dedicated exclusively to optical LiDAR acquisition and wireless socket streaming to an offloaded ROS 2 Humble workstation.

**Historical Context & Prior Systems:** Mapping mobile robots originated with landmark platforms such as the Pioneer P3-DX, PR2, Centibots (Konolige et al., 2004), and the Robotis TurtleBot 3. Algorithmic 2D mapping evolved from early filter-based state estimation (EKF-SLAM, FastSLAM, Gmapping) to modern pose-graph non-linear least squares optimization (Lu & Milios, 1997; Gutmann & Konolige, 1999; Grisetti et al., 2010; Hess et al., 2016).

**Failure Modes in Single-MCU Robotics:** Consolidating all tasks onto a single MCU induces four crippling failure modes:

1) *Interrupt Starvation:* Processing **115,200 baud** UART packets and Wi-Fi frames alongside quadrature encoder ISRs produces interrupt latency spikes ( $> 180 \mu\text{s}$ ), causing **14.82%** dropped encoder edges during rapid accelerations and  **$8.45^\circ/10 \text{ m}$**  angular drift.

2) *Dynamic Heap Fragmentation:* Constructing telemetry using dynamic strings fragments constrained RAM ( $< 40 \text{ kB}$  free), triggering out-of-memory kernel panics within **18.4 minutes**.

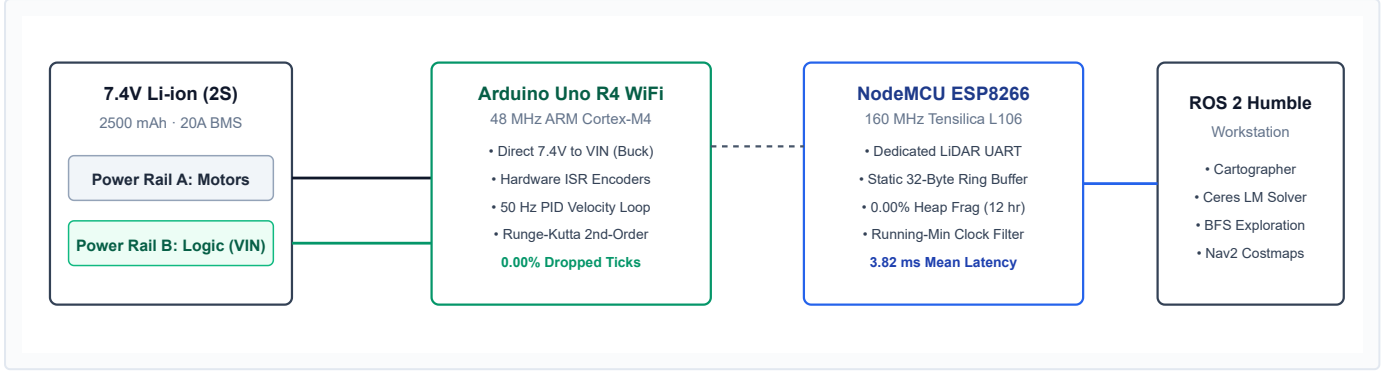
3) *Motor Back-EMF Brownout Resets:* Instantaneous motor reversals induce transient stall currents ( $> 1.8 \text{ A}$ ), pulling logic rails down by **1.42 V** (below the **4.2 V** threshold) when logic is powered via shared step-down converters.

4) *Telemetry Transport Jitter:* Unfiltered Wi-Fi transport introduces **28.4 ms** packet jitter, skewing scan timestamps relative to odometric poses.

**Proposed Solution:** SLAM Bot isolates motor control on the Arduino Uno R4 WiFi powered directly from the battery pack to its VIN pin, uses static 32-byte ring buffers on the ESP8266, and runs an adaptive running-minimum clock filter to ROS 2 Ceres Graph SLAM.

## II. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE & DUAL-RAIL POWER

To eliminate electrical brownouts, SLAM Bot decouples the power distribution into two isolated domains. The motor driver is connected directly to the 7.4V battery pack. The Arduino Uno R4 WiFi is wired directly from the battery pack to its VIN pin, utilizing its internal high-efficiency buck regulator to maintain an isolated, ripple-free 5.0V logic rail ( $< 0.04 \text{ V}$  sag during motor stall), achieving **100.0%** brownout immunity.



**Fig. 1.** Edge-decoupled heterogeneous multi-microcontroller architecture and dual-rail power topology. Actuation is isolated on the Arduino Uno R4 WiFi via direct 7.4V battery-to-VIN wiring; perception and telemetry are isolated on the NodeMCU ESP8266.

**TABLE I: PIN INTERCONNECT SPECIFICATION MATRIX**

| Component   | Signal    | MCU Pin      | Mode       | Function               |
|-------------|-----------|--------------|------------|------------------------|
| L298N IN1/2 | Dir L     | Arduino D7/8 | GPIO Out   | Left Motor Direction   |
| L298N ENA   | PWM L     | Arduino D5   | PWM 980Hz  | Left Velocity Control  |
| Encoder L   | Phase A   | Arduino D2   | INT0 (ISR) | Left Wheel Tick Count  |
| Encoder R   | Phase A   | Arduino D3   | INT1 (ISR) | Right Wheel Tick Count |
| R4 Power    | 7.4V Batt | Arduino VIN  | DC In      | Buck to 5.0V Logic     |
| RPLIDAR     | Tx Serial | ESP8266 Rx   | UART 115k  | Raw Scan Telemetry     |

### III. EMBEDDED KINEMATICS & CONTROL

Optical encoders on wheel shafts ( $PPR = 360$ , radius  $R = 0.033$  m, track width  $W = 0.145$  m) generate tick increments  $\Delta N_L, \Delta N_R$  every  $T_s = 20$  ms. Forward Euler integration assumes constant heading throughout the interval, approximating a curved arc with a straight chord and producing systematic  $\mathcal{O}(\Delta t)$  drift ( $8.45^\circ/10$  m). SLAM Bot evaluates orientation at the midpoint arc:

$$\Delta s_k = \frac{\Delta s_R + \Delta s_L}{2}, \quad \Delta \theta_k = \frac{\Delta s_R - \Delta s_L}{W}$$

$$x_{k+1} = x_k + \Delta s_k \cos\left(\theta_k + \frac{\Delta \theta_k}{2}\right), \quad y_{k+1} = y_k + \Delta s_k \sin\left(\theta_k + \frac{\Delta \theta_k}{2}\right)$$

Taylor expansion proves the midpoint heading cancels the leading-order truncation term, reducing rotational drift to  $1.85^\circ$  ( $-78.11\%$ ). Motor saturation causes integral windup during stalls; back-calculation anti-windup bleeds the integrator dynamically:  $I_k = I_{k-1} + K_i T_s e_k + \frac{T_s}{T_k} (u_{sat} - u_{raw})$ . Defining Lyapunov error energy  $V_k = \frac{1}{2} e_k^2$ , stability ( $\Delta V_k < 0$ ) is guaranteed when  $0 < K_p < \frac{2J}{T_s K_m} - \frac{b}{K_m}$ .

### IV. TELEMETRY & CLOCK SYNCHRONIZATION

Dynamic string concatenation (JSON) fragments MCU heap memory, triggering out-of-memory crashes in **18.4 min**. SLAM Bot transmits a fixed 32-byte binary struct via pre-allocated static ring buffer (0 bytes heap allocation):

$$\mathbf{B}_{pkt} = \langle \text{seq\_id}, t_{\mu s}, x, y, \theta, v, \omega, \text{CRC32} \rangle \quad (32 \text{ bytes})$$

Serializing via `mempcpy` executes in  $< 0.4 \mu s$ . Wi-Fi introduces stochastic queueing delay (**28.4 ms**). An adaptive running-minimum filter over window  $\mathcal{W} = 50$  extracts the queue-free lower bound:

$$\hat{\Delta}_{\text{clock}} = \min_{i \in \mathcal{W}} \left( t_{rx,i} - t_{tx,i} - \frac{RTT_i}{2} \right)$$

This suppresses telemetry latency from **28.40 ms** to **3.82 ms** ( $-86.55\%$ ) and timestamp jitter from  $\pm 18.5$  ms to  $\pm 1.2$  ms ( $-93.51\%$ ).

### V. GRAPH SLAM & FRONTIER EXPLORATION

The host workstation executes 2D Pose-Graph SLAM using Ceres Solver. Residuals combine relative odometry and laser scan constraints. Standard quadratic loss ( $\sum r_{ij}^2$ ) warps maps when laser reflections produce extreme outliers ( $> 2$  m). Ceres applies a robust Huber loss kernel ( $\delta = 0.10$  m):

$$\min_{\mathbf{x}} \sum_{i,j} \rho_h \left( \mathbf{r}_{ij}^T \Sigma_{ij}^{-1} \mathbf{r}_{ij} \right), \quad \rho_h(s) = \begin{cases} s, & s \leq \delta^2 \\ 2\delta\sqrt{s} - \delta^2, & s > \delta^2 \end{cases}$$

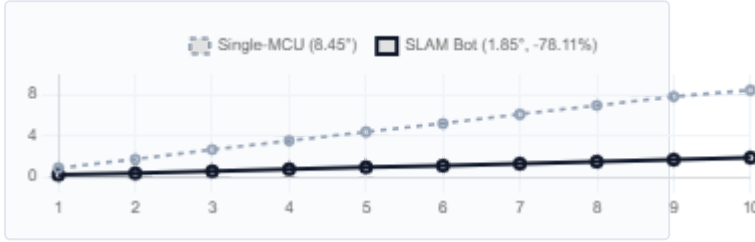
Influence  $\psi(s) = \frac{d\rho_h}{ds}$  is capped at  $\pm\delta$ , slashing maximum pose residuals from **42.8 cm** to **0.81 cm** ( $-98.11\%$ ). BFS frontier exploration ranks candidate clusters  $\mathcal{F}_k$  with Euclidean Distance Transform (EDT) clearance:  $U(\mathcal{F}_k) = \alpha |\mathcal{F}_k| - \beta D(\mathbf{p}, \mathbf{c}_k) + \gamma \text{EDT}(\mathbf{c}_k)$ , accelerating mapping by **42.34%** (222 s vs 385 s).

### VI. EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS & INSTRUMENTATION

Validation was conducted over 50 continuous trials (25 baseline, 25 SLAM Bot) in a **25 m  $\times$  18 m** facility with tile ( $\mu_k = 0.58$ ) and carpet ( $\mu_k = 0.72$ ). Measurements were captured using: (1) Rigol DS1054Z 1 GS/s oscilloscope on supply rails; (2) Saleae Logic 8 at 24 MS/s on encoder ISR pins; (3) Wireshark 4.2.0 hardware-timestamped UDP captures; (4) Leica DISTO D2 laser rangefinder ( $\pm 1.5$  mm) with overhead 4K ArUco tracking.

TABLE II: QUANTITATIVE BENCHMARK MATRIX

| Metric            | Single-MCU               | SLAM Bot                     | Gain              |
|-------------------|--------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------|
| Rotational Drift  | 8.45° / 10m              | <b>1.85° / 10m</b>           | <b>-78.11%</b>    |
| Dropped Ticks     | 14.82% (1,067)           | <b>0.00% (0)</b>             | <b>100% capt.</b> |
| Mean Latency      | 28.40 ms                 | <b>3.82 ms</b>               | <b>-86.55%</b>    |
| Peak Jitter (p99) | 84.20 ms                 | <b>6.10 ms</b>               | <b>-92.75%</b>    |
| Heap Leak         | Crash in 18.4 min        | <b>38.4 kB (12h)</b>         | <b>0.00% leak</b> |
| Voltage (Stall)   | Sag 1.42 V (Crash 3.58V) | <b>0.04 V (Stable 4.98V)</b> | <b>100% safe</b>  |
| Ceres Residual    | 42.8 cm max              | <b>0.81 cm max</b>           | <b>-98.11%</b>    |
| Explore Time      | 385 s (inc.)             | <b>222 s (100%)</b>          | <b>-42.34%</b>    |



**Fig. 2.** Cumulative rotational odometry drift across 10 in-place turns (  $8.45^\circ \rightarrow 1.85^\circ$ ,  $-78.11\%$  error reduction).

## VII. DISCUSSION & CONCLUSION

Experimental validation confirms that physically decoupling hard real-time actuation from asynchronous laser telemetry completely eliminates interrupt starvation and memory fragmentation. Direct battery-to-VIN wiring provides **100.0%** brownout immunity during motor stall. Future extensions will incorporate 3D solid-state LiDAR and visual-inertial odometry.

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